



Planning

Given a customer scenario involving a new Salesforce release (Summer, Winter, Spring), recommend the appropriate strategy to mitigate risks.

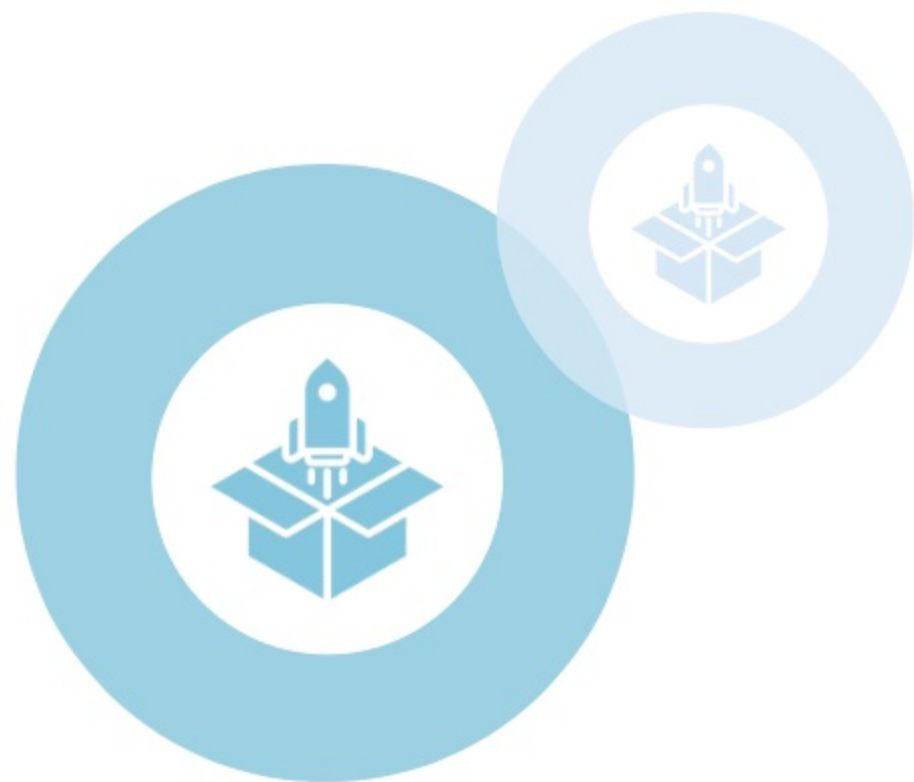
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After studying this topic, you should be able to:

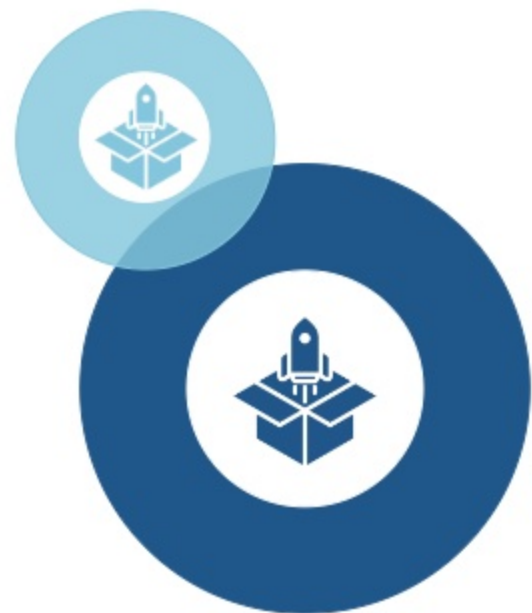
-  Identify the various aspects of Salesforce releases that should be considered for release readiness.
-  Describe how to generate a preview sandbox to test new features prior to a Salesforce release.
-  Identify the considerations related to the use of release notes.
-  Describe the principles that should be followed for the testing and implementation of new features.
-  Identify the different types of testing and the related considerations.



Introduction

Salesforce releases new features and enhancements three times a year during the **Spring, Summer and Winter seasons**. A **preview sandbox** can be used to test new features before they are released in the production environment. The **location of a sandbox (preview or non-preview instance)** depends on the timing of its most recent refresh.

Release Notes should be reviewed to identify the different types of features in a release. **Change management principles** should be followed for the implementation of new features. Various **types of testing**, such as unit testing, functional testing, and regression testing, can be conducted in a preview sandbox prior to a release.



Salesforce Releases & Risk Mitigation

Seasonal Releases

Salesforce releases new features and enhancements three times a year during the Spring, Summer and Winter seasons.



Preview Sandbox

A sandbox can be refreshed during the preview window to test new features before their general release in production.



Release Notes

Filters can be used to find specific updates in release notes. They contain various sections that can be checked.



Implementation

Change management principles should be followed for implementing new features in a Salesforce release.



Testing

Various types of testing can be performed in a preview sandbox before a release hits the production org.



Considerations

Various considerations are applicable for testing new features before a release.



Salesforce Releases

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Salesforce Releases

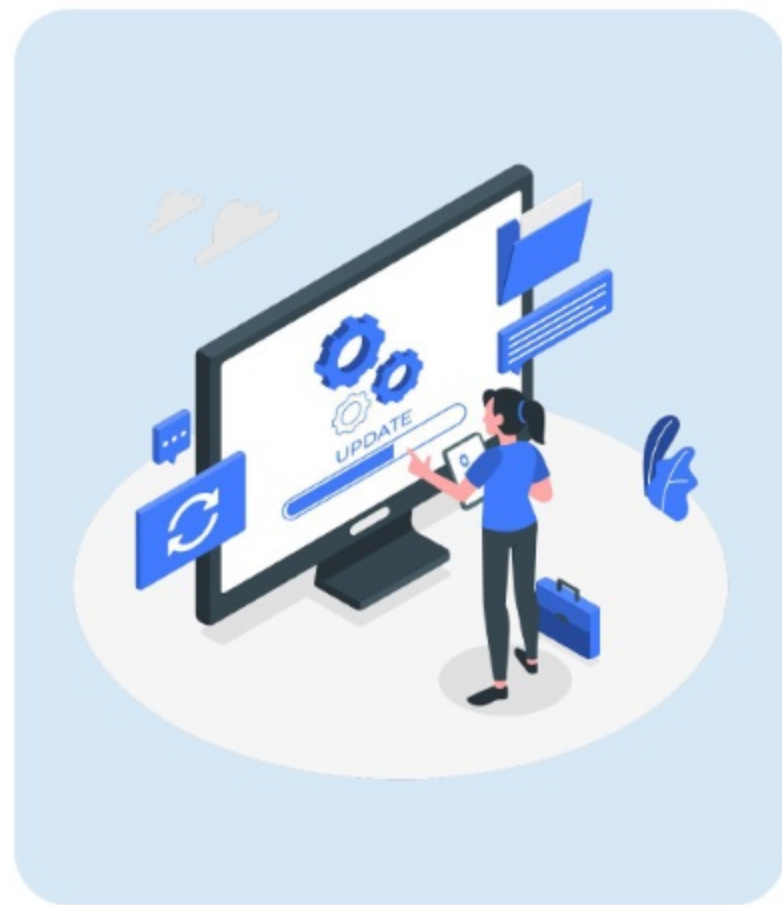
Salesforce **releases new features** and **enhancements** three times a year during the **Spring, Summer,** and **Winter** seasons.

◆ UPGRADES

Each release brings **automatic, seamless upgrades** with **minimal scheduled maintenance**, ensuring all customers run on the same, latest version of Salesforce.

◆ RELEASE CYCLE

The release cycle starts approximately **3 months before live production**, with sandbox instances upgraded **4-6 weeks prior to production release**.



Salesforce Releases

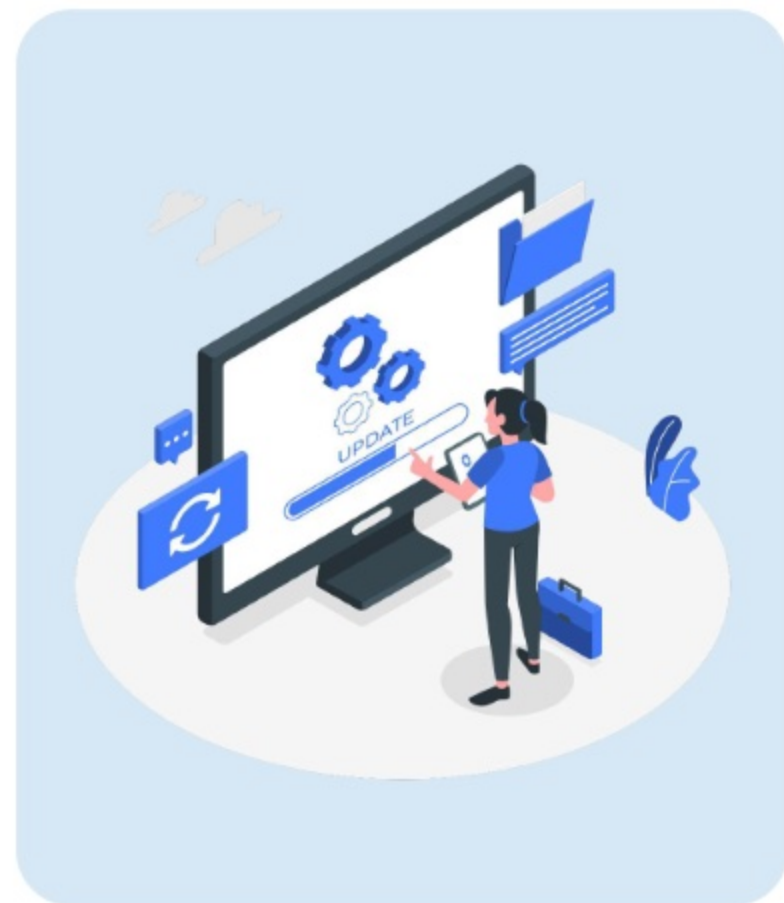
Salesforce **releases new features** and **enhancements** three times a year during the **Spring**, **Summer**, and **Winter** seasons.

❖ SALESFORCE TRUST

Release dates are published **up to a year in advance** on the Salesforce Trust website, allowing for early planning.

❖ LIGHTNING EXPERIENCE

Lightning Experience is the **focus of innovation** in Salesforce releases, bringing **productivity boosts** and **new features** not available in Salesforce Classic.



Sandbox Preview

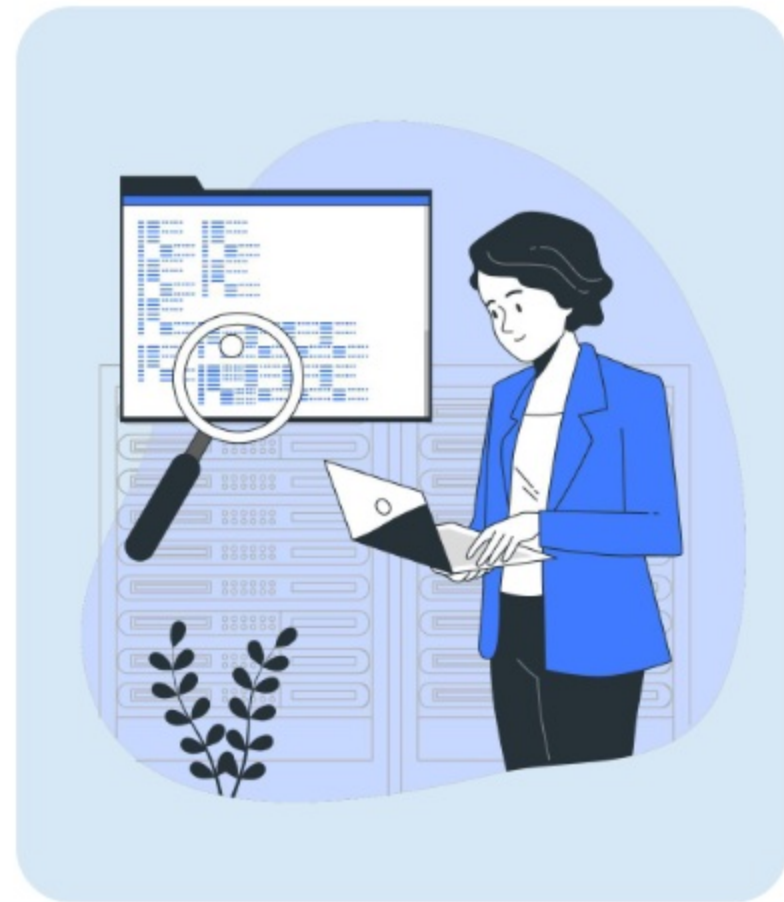
Sandboxes allow **previewing and testing new Salesforce features** before their general release.

❖ EARLY ACCESS

Preview sandboxes provide early access to new features about **4-6 weeks before the production upgrade**, enabling evaluation and user communication.

❖ NON-PREVIEW

Not all sandboxes are eligible for early upgrades; **'non-preview' sandboxes** receive updates later, sometimes after production release.



Sandbox Preview

Sandboxes allow **previewing and testing new Salesforce features** before their general release.

◆ SANDBOX LOCATION

The location of a **sandbox (preview or non-preview instance)** depends on the **timing of its most recent refresh**. If a sandbox is **refreshed** during the **sandbox preview period**, it is moved to a **non-preview instance**.

◆ PREVIEW ACCESS

Refreshing a sandbox **before the sandbox preview cut-off date** sends it to a **preview instance**. To ensure access, the sandbox should be maintained **without refreshing it after the cut-off date**.



Sandbox Preview

Sandboxes allow **previewing and testing new Salesforce features** before their general release.

❖ PREVIEW GUIDE

The **Salesforce Sandbox Preview Guide** can be used to ensure access to a preview sandbox that gets an early upgrade.

❖ RECOMMENDATIONS

Each **sandbox instance** can be looked up in the guide to see if it's a **preview or non-preview instance**. **Recommendations** can be followed to ensure that there's at least one sandbox on a preview instance.



Release Notes

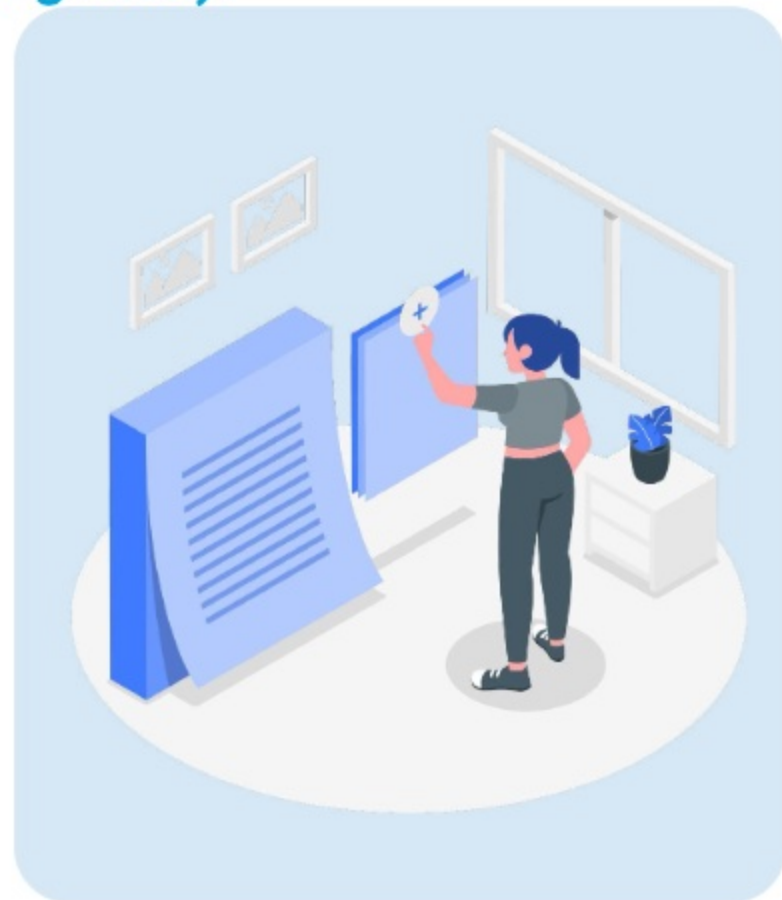
Release Notes filters can be used to identify features that are **automatically enabled (Quick Wins)** and those that need **minimal admin action (Low-hanging Fruit)**.

❖ FEEDBACK

Super users can be engaged for **feedback on Quick Wins** and **Low-hanging Fruit** to ensure user relevance and facilitate training.

❖ COMMUNICATION

Upcoming release details should be **communicated to users and stakeholders**, focusing on **benefits** and **incorporating feedback** for phased rollouts. **Communication channels** that can be considered include in-app notifications, customized help menu, email, newsletters, cheat sheets, lunch and learns, virtual meetings, and webinars.



Release Notes

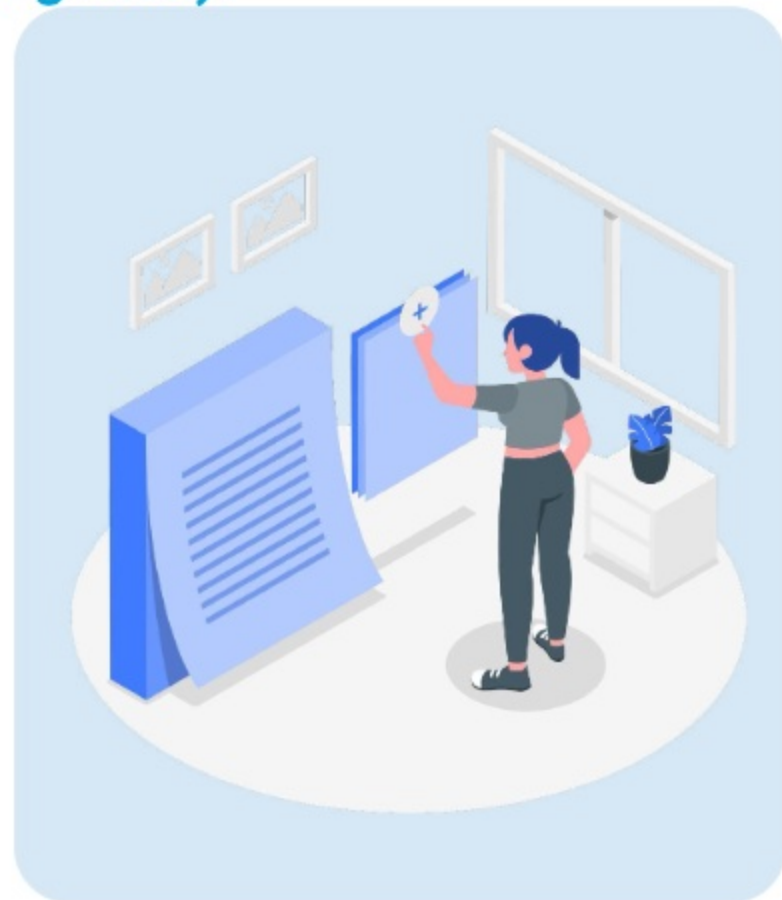
Release Notes filters can be used to identify features that are **automatically enabled (Quick Wins)** and those that need **minimal admin action (Low-hanging Fruit)**.

❖ SECTIONS

The various sections in the release notes can be used as reference or to check for updates. It is possible to **drill down by cloud** as well as **cloud-independent areas** such as Analytics.

❖ PROCESS

This process should be repeated every three months: **mark calendar dates, engage with community, preview in sandbox, review Release Notes**, and **prepare users**.



Pre-Release Org

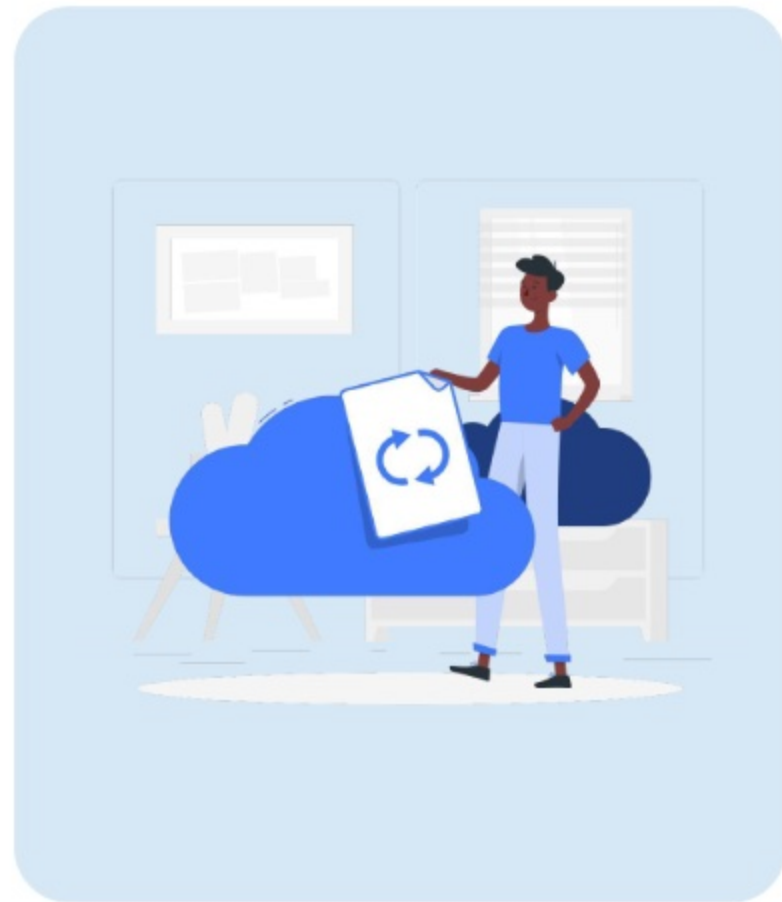
A **pre-release org** allows getting the **earliest possible look** at new features in action.

❖ AVAILABILITY

Sign-up for a **pre-release org** is available **3-4 weeks before the sandbox preview** starts.

❖ CUSTOMIZATIONS

A pre-release org **does not contain** any of the **customizations**, but they can be used to get a sneak peek at what's coming.



Benefits of New Features

There are several **benefits of new features** released by Salesforce.

NEW FUNCTIONALITY

New functionality is delivered to users without custom code or third-party apps.

IMPROVEMENTS

Existing customizations are improved by eliminating workarounds or limitations.

REDUCED TECHNICAL DEBT

Unnecessary complexity or technical debt is removed, reducing time to deploy.

SIMPLIFIED BACKLOG

Customizations in the backlog are simplified or enhanced.

Implementation of New Features

New features should be implemented by following **change management principles**.



Forward planning should be used to ensure that the needed technical resources are available. Planning can be started two months before the release in production (early December, April, and August).



Roles, responsibilities, and processes should be defined. Several individuals or teams may be responsible. Examples include product owners, subject matter experts, and technical experts.



Advanced tools such as the **Release Matrix** and a **Release Management custom object** can be used to manage release updates and make it easier to collaborate around prioritization and deployment.

Testing of New Features

The **testing approach** for new features depends on the **complexity** of the Salesforce org. The **three change management principles** should be considered.



Time for testing activities should be factored in ahead of a Salesforce release deployment. The **required people and testing environments** should be considered. Other Salesforce project schedules may need to be **adjusted**.



New features that **impact the user experience**, such as changes to the user interface, and any existing custom code, should be tested. Tests should be conducted in a **sandbox preview** upgraded with the new Salesforce release.



Automated testing tools, called **CI (Continuous Integration)** tools, can be used when there are multiple developers or complex custom code. Considerations such as cost, in-house expertise, and compatibility are applicable.

Types of Testing

There are **five main types of testing** that can be utilized for testing new features.



Unit tests are used to test smallest bits of custom code to catch bugs early.



Integration tests are used to test code interactions with anything not native in the org.



Functional tests verify that features work as defined in the technical requirements.



User-acceptance testing allows end users to accept or reject the final feature delivery.



Performance testing evaluates system response when large volumes of records or operations are being handled.

Testing Considerations

There are various **considerations for testing new features** before a release.

SANDBOX MANAGEMENT

One or more sandboxes need to be created for testing. Reliable re-execution of tests requires a refresh or reset.

TEST DATA

Test data needs to be generated using a suitable approach in developer sandboxes since they do not contain any production data.

INTEGRATION TESTING

Integration with third-party systems requires running tests on both sides of the integration.

API & UI TESTING

API tests should be used instead of UI tests wherever possible since UI testing is costly to maintain. A dedicated UI tool should be used.

PERFORMANCE TESTING

It is necessary to ensure that governor limits are not reached during performance tests. They should not be automated.

SALESFORCE CLASSIC TESTING

Some tests built for Salesforce Classic won't run in Lightning Experience, so it may be necessary to rebuild them.

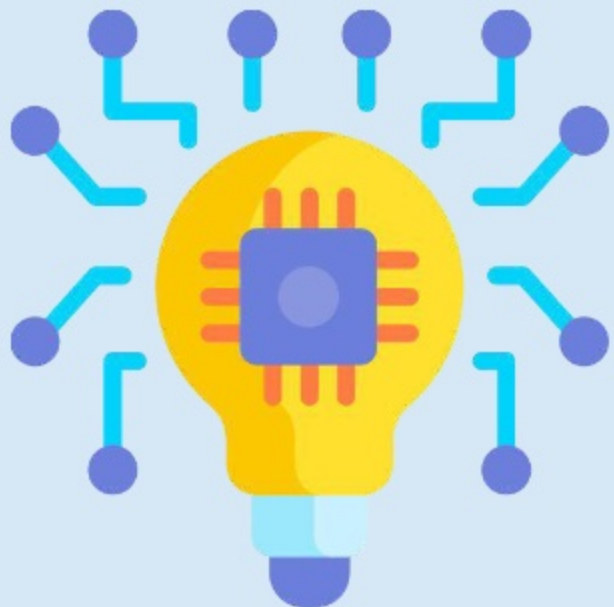
Business Scenario

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Business Scenario

Read the business scenario below and determine the most appropriate solutions for the company's requirements.



Cosmic Innovations is a global enterprise with a vast Salesforce implementation spanning multiple business units, including sales, customer service, and marketing. The company leverages Salesforce for a wide range of processes and custom applications, making the regular Salesforce seasonal releases (Spring, Summer, and Winter) crucial for the organization.

With the upcoming Salesforce Spring release, it faces the challenge of aligning its major, minor, and Salesforce seasonal releases to minimize disruption and maximize the benefits of new features. Additionally, there exist challenges related to release planning and deployment practices. A Salesforce architect has been hired to recommend the appropriate strategies based on the company's requirements.

Requirements & Solutions

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Requirement 1



SCENARIO

The CTO of the company has noticed that the misalignment of release cycles between Salesforce seasonal releases and internal major and minor releases is leading to inefficiencies and increased risk. An upcoming major release will be deployed one week after Salesforce updates the production org. The current deployment plan does not account for the Salesforce Spring release and the time required for refreshing the full sandbox, potentially delaying the deployment of critical updates.

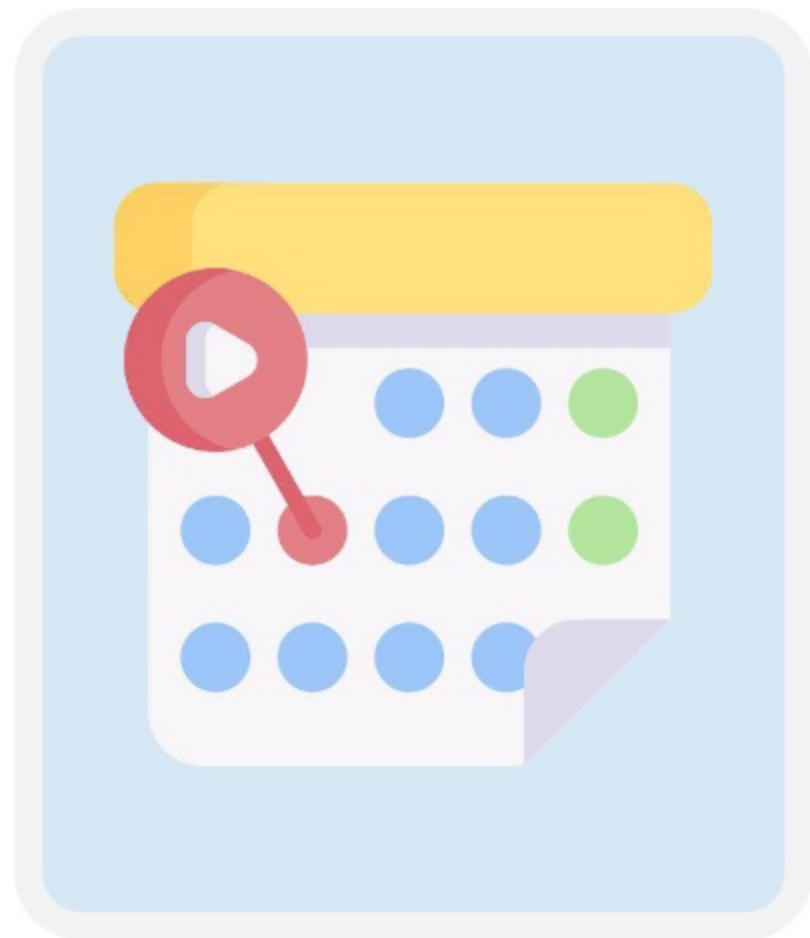


Solution 1

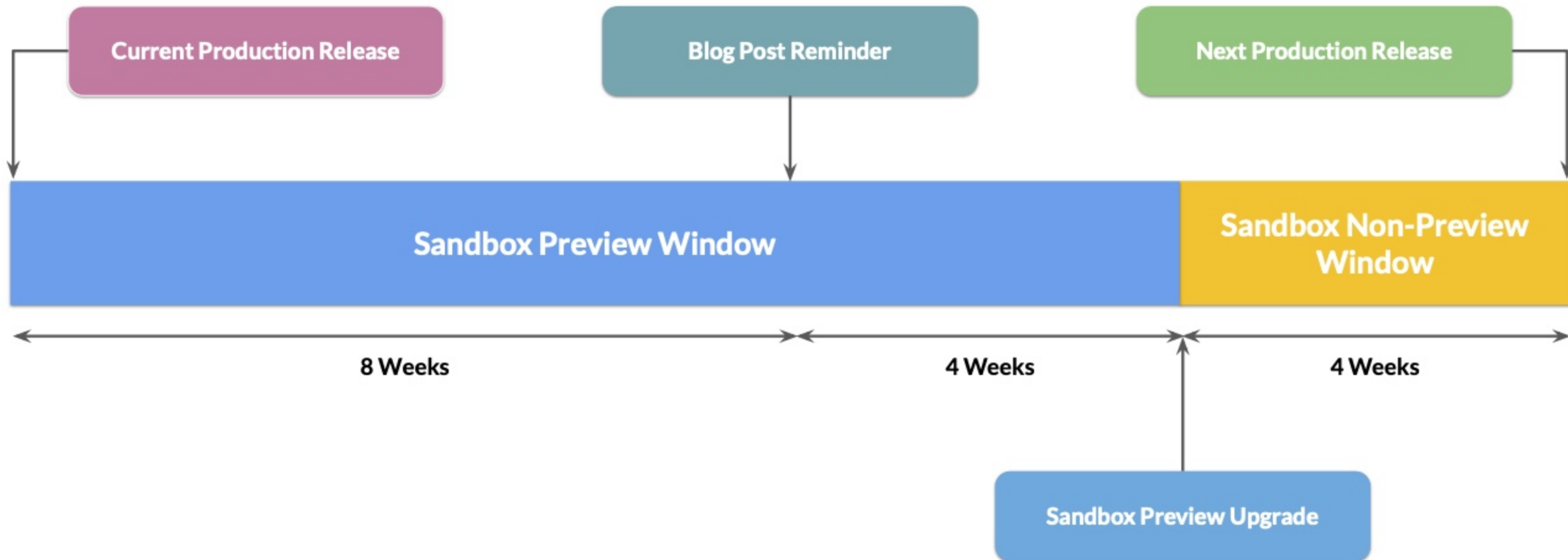


SOLUTION

The company should establish a comprehensive **release calendar** that aligns Salesforce seasonal releases with the internal release cycles. This calendar should be used to **train and align** all relevant teams, ensuring everyone is prepared for upcoming releases. In addition, the deployment plan should account for the production environment update and sandbox refresh time. To ensure seamless testing and deployment, the full sandbox should be **refreshed approximately six weeks before go-live** to ensure that it is on a **preview instance** for the purpose of testing. Once testing is complete and Salesforce has updated the production environment, the changes can be deployed to production.



Solution 1



Requirement 2



SCENARIO

A development team is facing issues while deploying metadata from a developer pro sandbox to a partial copy sandbox used for user-acceptance testing. The UAT sandbox is not recognizing some new Salesforce metadata types. There was no issue while deploying the same metadata from a developer sandbox to the developer pro sandbox. With several ongoing development projects, the company needs a robust strategy to prepare for the Salesforce release without impacting these projects.



Solution 2



SOLUTION

The discrepancy between the two sandbox environments is most likely because the developer pro sandbox is on a **preview release** but the partial copy sandbox is not. It is important to ensure that both environments are on the **same Salesforce release** version to facilitate smooth metadata deployment. Additionally, the **release strategy** should include thoroughly **reviewing the release notes** for automatically-enabled features, features that require manual intervention, and areas of testing, **refreshing a sandbox during the release preview window** to test the upcoming release, and **running regression tests** in an upgraded sandbox to detect any issues.



Learn More

-  [Salesforce Release Readiness Strategies](#)
-  [Advanced Salesforce Release Readiness Strategies](#)

